

THE MOMENTUM EXECUTIVE BRIEF

DATA READINESS | IMPLEMENTATION



Why Clean Data Comes First

Lessons from an Implementation That Almost Went Wrong

PREPARED FOR:

Business, Operations, Supply Chain, and Quality leaders — and the project managers driving system migrations, reporting upgrades, and automation across HCM, HRIS, and ERP platforms.

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Executive Summary

Most implementation problems don't begin at go-live. They begin months — sometimes years — earlier, buried inside the data nobody thought to question.

Organizations invest in new Human Resources Information System (HRIS), Human Capital Management (HCM), payroll, applicant tracking, ERP, reporting, or workflow systems expecting sharper visibility, cleaner processes, and stronger automation. But when the data feeding those systems is incomplete, inconsistent, outdated, duplicated, or poorly structured, the new platform inherits the very problems it was meant to solve.

Gartner puts the average cost of poor data quality at \$12.9 million a year [1] — reason enough to treat data quality as a leadership issue rather than an afterthought. IBM's migration guidance goes further, arguing that understanding data, who uses it, and how it will be used has to happen before migration activity begins [2].

This brief makes the case for a shift in how projects get scoped: data readiness deserves the same formal standing as configuration and testing, not a slot late in the schedule reserved for cleanup. It walks through the data issues that most often derail projects, the hidden business logic living inside legacy files, the federal and state compliance stakes riding on the same data, and five lessons one project taught about preparing data before configuration, testing, or go-live.

It closes with a practical readiness framework any organization can apply to an HRIS, payroll, ERP, reporting, or automation initiative — because clean data isn't a technical detail sitting outside the project. It's the foundation project success, operational trust, and real system adoption are built on.

“The lesson from this project is simple: data should be prepared before it becomes a liability — not managed as one after the fact.”

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The Lesson Most Organizations Learn Too Late

A brand-new system will not fix bad data. A new system may offer a cleaner structure to scale business processes, and if your nice to implementation team, you might be able get it configured to flag inaccurate records duplicate information or missing fields — but it cannot resolve inconsistent naming, unclear ownership, or undocumented business rules on its own. Those are behavioral problems, and they would warrant human intervention.

What does bad data look like — and how does it get that way?

How does bad data start? Usually, the same way debt does *quietly*, one shortcut at a time. The system is only as good as the data that is stored. When was the last time you had a formal or even informal review of the data inside your HCM, MRP, ERP or HRIS? Once you have reviewed your data, and you discover concerns, leaders should talk to the teams who are responsible for entering or validating the data and discuss their concerns. If you could re-implement your current vendor, what fields (no matter the form, module, etc. should be required and or completely spelled out. If Workflows are present, and active, will these workflows accept similar inconsistent data?

Reporting is your Best Friend

What does bad data look like? A department renames a field. An export gets copied instead of refreshed. A workaround becomes policy because no one ever wrote down the original rule. Common abbreviations are used for the same word in multiple instances.

When organizations delay data preparation, these problems surface during configuration, file mapping, testing, or go-live prep — exactly when the timeline is tightest, decisions are moving fastest, and teams have the least room to slow down and fix things properly.

Missing critical data should warrant a root-cause analysis. The most efficient way to review your data is **Reporting**. Every system will come with some sort of reporting module that can produce an excel export. In some cases, the even better platforms will have come with a Custom Reporting area as well. This will allow you build custom reports at your leisure and review the latest inputs and approvals.

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Common Data Issues That Slow Projects Down

Implementation teams tend to hit the same handful of issues, and each looks minor in isolation:

- Duplicate employee, client, vendor, or project records
- Missing required fields or inconsistent formats
- Multiple versions of the same spreadsheet or export
- Mismatched IDs across systems, with no clear source of truth
- Legacy codes, formulas, or values nobody can fully explain anymore

Together, they compound. A duplicate vendor record becomes a duplicate payment. A mismatched ID becomes a reconciliation project. An unexplained legacy formula becomes a support ticket six months after go-live — the kind that starts with “why does the system do that?”

Why Data Readiness Matters

Data readiness is the discipline of reviewing, cleaning, validating, organizing, and preparing information before it is migrated, imported, integrated, reported on, or automated. The UK Government Data Quality Hub and IBM both frame this around a consistent set of dimensions [3][4]:

- Accuracy — does the value reflect reality?
- Completeness — is anything required missing?
- Consistency — does the same fact look the same everywhere?
- Timeliness — is the data current enough to act on?
- Validity — does it conform to the format and rules a system expects?
- Uniqueness — does each real-world record exist exactly once?

A *readiness* process forces the right questions early, while there's still time to act on the answers: What data needs to move? Where does it live today? Which fields are required, and which are legacy clutter? Who owns each source? What should be archived instead of migrated? Which business rules need to travel with the data?

Answer these early, and the project team makes sharper decisions, avoids rework, and walks into testing and go-live with real confidence — not hope.

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The Hidden Business Logic Layer

There's a second reason legacy data deserves scrutiny: it often reveals how the business operates — not how the org chart says it operates.

A spreadsheet, payroll export, ERP report, or legacy tracker is rarely just records. It's frequently carrying hidden business logic: approval patterns, exception handling, naming habits, department workarounds, reporting shortcuts, compensation rules, and operational decisions that were never formally documented anywhere else.

Research on business rule mining from spreadsheets backs this up: organizations run a significant share of their operations and decision-making through spreadsheets, which makes those files genuinely rich in embedded business rules [6]. The practical implication is simple — before data moves, it should be studied, not just exported.



Figure 1. Legacy files carry a visible data layer — and a hidden rules layer beneath it.

The Legal and Regulatory Perspective

Data readiness isn't only an efficiency question. Increasingly, it's becoming more of a compliance one — and the exposure runs on two tracks: what federal law already requires you to keep accurate, and what a growing list of state laws now requires you to know, control, and be able to correct.

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Federal: Recordkeeping Assumes the Data is Correct

The [Fair Labor Standards Act](#) requires employers to maintain specific records for every non-exempt worker — identifying information, hours worked, pay rate, and wage calculations — and to preserve payroll records for at least three years, with wage-calculation backup like timecards held for two [8]. [Equal Employment Opportunity Commission](#) rules layer on their own retention duties: payroll and benefit plan records for at least three years under the ADEA, and once a charge is filed, related personnel records must be kept until the matter is fully resolved [9].

None of these rules assume messy data. They assume an employer can produce a complete, accurate record on request. A migration that drops historical wage fields, merges employee IDs incorrectly, or leaves gaps in pay-change history doesn't just create an operational headache — it can leave a business unable to satisfy a [Department of Labor audit](#) or an EEOC inquiry with confidence.

State: The patchwork is catching up to HR data

With no comprehensive federal privacy law, states have moved individually — and the list keeps growing. Texas is a useful example of where this is headed. The [Texas Data Privacy and Security Act](#), in force since July 2024, applies to nearly any business that processes Texas residents' personal data, with a narrower small-business exemption than comparable state laws and no revenue threshold to hide behind [10]. It grants individuals rights to access, correct, and delete their data, and requires businesses to maintain reasonable administrative and technical safeguards around it. Texas has since layered on the [Responsible AI Governance Act](#), effective January 1, 2026, extending data-protection obligations to AI systems that process personal data [11] — directly relevant as more readiness and automation projects lean on AI-assisted matching and cleanup.

Texas is not unique on this subject. California, Virginia, Colorado, Connecticut, and a lengthening list of other states have each passed their own version, with their own definitions and deadlines. For any organization operating across state lines, that patchwork means the same employee or customer record can carry different legal obligations depending on where the person lives.

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Where Readiness and Compliance Overlap

A system migration is often the first time in years that anyone systematically reviews what personal data an organization holds, where it lives, who owns it, and whether it's accurate. That is, not coincidentally, close to what these laws require directly: a data inventory, a way to correct inaccurate records, a defined retention schedule, and clear ownership. Organizations that treat data readiness and legal compliance as two separate initiatives end up doing the same review twice. Organizations that fold compliance requirements into the readiness process get it as a byproduct of the work they were already planning to do.

This section is general information, and not legal advice — recordkeeping and privacy obligations vary by state and industry, and organizations should confirm specific requirements with qualified counsel.

Five Lessons from the Project

Lesson 1: Data cleanup starts before configuration, not after

Configuration decisions — workflows, reporting, permissions, required fields — all rest on assumptions about how the organization works **today** and **wants** to work tomorrow. Clean data gives the project team a foundation solid enough to build those decisions on. So, this process is generally positioned before you get your CEO to sign-off the new system expense. We will discuss why in a future *Momentum Executive Brief*.

Lesson 2: Every field needs to earn its place

Not everything in the legacy system deserves to migrate. Some data is outdated, duplicated, or better suited to an archive than an active system. Moving everything forward “just in case” doesn't preserve value — it relocates the clutter.

Lesson 3: Inconsistency is Invisible to Individuals and Expensive to Systems

One department writes “Full-Time.” Another writes “FT.” A third writes “Regular.” To a person, these obviously mean the same thing. To a system, they are three (3) separate categories — and every downstream report inherits the fracture.

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Lesson 4: Ownership Isn't Optional

Data problems are rarely solved by technology alone; someone must understand the business meaning behind the records. ISO 8000-150:2022 treats roles and responsibilities as a core pillar of data quality management for exactly this reason [5].

Lesson 5: Testing is only as good as the data behind it

User acceptance testing, payroll parallel runs, workflow testing, reporting validation, and migration testing all depend on reliable data. Prepared data allows testing to do its real job — confirming the system is ready, instead of exposing data problems that should have been caught weeks earlier.

The Cost of Waiting

Delay data preparation, and the strain doesn't disappear — it resurfaces somewhere more expensive to fix. Timelines stretch. Business users lose confidence. Reports stop reconciling. Payroll and operational testing turn into repeated correction cycles instead of validation exercises.

The later a data issue surfaces, the more it costs to fix — and the more it tempts teams under pressure to apply a quick patch instead of a real one. Those patches have a way of outliving the project. They become the questions asked eighteen months after go-live that start with “why does the system do that?”

“Data readiness doesn't add time to a project. It removes the surprises that were going to cost time anyway.”

A Sound Approach

Organizations, their respective suppliers, and vendors, should treat data readiness as a formal phase of implementation planning, not a contingency. DAMA-DMBOK remains the standard reference for structured data management practice, and ISO 8000 reinforces the same point

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from a different angle: accountability and documented roles aren't nice-to-haves in data quality work — they're the mechanism that makes it stick [5][7].

A practical readiness process typically includes:

- Reviewing current data sources and identifying required fields
- Removing duplicate or outdated records
- Standardizing naming conventions and formats
- Mapping legacy fields to the future system
- Validating records with business owners
- Documenting business rules and exceptions
- Preparing test files ahead of migration
- Confirming final ownership before load or go-live

The Momentum Data Readiness Framework

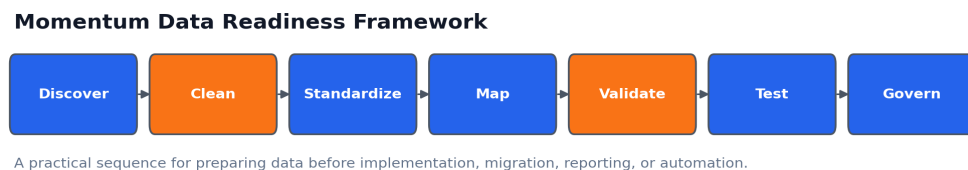


Figure 2. Discover the data, clean what's wrong, standardize what varies, map what must move, validate what matters, test the outcome, and govern what remains.

How Momentum Data Solutions Supports the Process

Momentum Data Solutions helps organizations prepare data before implementation, migration, reporting, or automation work begins — starting with the source systems, file formats, business rules, project requirements, and the outcomes leadership cares about.

From there, Momentum extracts, validates, cleans, transforms, and organizes information so it's genuinely usable, not just present. Depending on a client's systems, that work may run through spreadsheets, secure exports, APIs, webhooks, connectors, or full ETL workflows.

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The goal isn't simply cleaner data. It's making sure organizations understand what their data is telling them before they build a new system on top of it.

Conclusion

A system implementation is never only a technology project. It is a data project. A process project. A readiness project. And more often than teams expect, it becomes a project that surfaces uncomfortable truths about how the business runs — not how the org chart says it runs, not how the last training deck described it, but how it *operates* when no one is looking.

This is the truth that vendors won't tell you in the sales cycle, and that implementation timelines rarely account for: the system is not the risk. The system is the mirror. It reflects, with unforgiving clarity, every workaround, every undocumented exception, every "we've always just done it this way" that has quietly accumulated over years of operating without anyone stopping to ask whether the data underneath could support what the business has become.

The organizations that emerge from these transitions stronger aren't the ones with the newest platform or the most sophisticated automation. They're the ones who understood, going in, that technology adoption is not a substitute for organizational discipline — it's a stress test of it. They treated data readiness not as a checkbox before go-live, but as the foundation the entire initiative would be built on.

As cloud-based, intelligent systems become more capable — and more appealing — the temptation will only grow to believe that a better vendor, a smarter platform, or a more advanced AI layer can compensate for what hasn't been addressed underneath. It can't. No system, however intelligent, can reason its way around bad data, undocumented process, or a workforce that doesn't trust what it's being asked to use. Intelligence amplifies what you feed it — clarity becomes insight, and disorder becomes disorder at scale.

The organizations considering their next migration — whether to a new payroll platform, a unified HRIS, or a global ERP — face a choice that has nothing to do with vendor selection. The real decision is whether to keep managing complexity reactively, one exception at a time, or to finally build the readiness that makes complexity manageable by design.

That choice doesn't have to be made alone, and it doesn't have to be made in the dark. Data readiness is not a mystery — it's a discipline, and it's one that can be assessed, planned for, and

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executed with confidence before the first module is ever configured. The organizations that get this right don't just implement systems successfully. They build the kind of operational clarity that outlasts any single platform, any single vendor, any single go-live date.

The system you choose next will only be as good as the truth you're willing to face before you choose it.

"Clean data doesn't just support the implementation. It determines whether the implementation succeeds."

About Momentum Data Solutions

Momentum Data Solutions supports organizations with data extraction, preparation, cleanup, transformation, reporting readiness, workflow support, and implementation-related data services. Through Momentum Insights and the Momentum Briefs series, Momentum Data shares practical lessons for organizations navigating system change, data movement, automation, and operational improvement.

Thank you

Whether this is your first interaction with us, or you are a current client, thank you! We appreciate your interest in our work and the opportunity to share how Momentum Data Solutions helps organizations transform complex data, disconnected processes, and operational challenges into clear, secure, and actionable solutions.

Our commitment is to provide practical strategies, measurable outcomes, and technology-supported services that strengthen decision-making and create lasting business value. We look forward to the opportunity to learn more about your organization's priorities and explore how we can help build meaningful momentum toward your goals.

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